

CASE STUDY



ECONOMIC VIABILITY OF HASS AVOCADO PRODUCTION IN THE RWENZORI REGION – KYENJOJO DISTRICT



EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Hass avocado production is rapidly emerging as a profitable enterprise for small scale farmers in Uganda. While Wakiso District in Central Uganda has demonstrated strong economic returns, the Rwen-zori Region—particularly Kyenjojo District—offers unique opportunities due to fertile soils, favorable climate, and proximity to Royal Plant Nurseries (RPN). This case study examines the viability of Hass avocado farming in Kyenjojo, highlighting RPN's role in providing seedlings, extension services, and market linkages. It explores farmer incomes, community impact, government support, and challenges, positioning Hass avocado as a driver of rural transformation under the Parish Development Model (PDM).



BACKGROUND

The Rwenzori Region is known for its rich volcanic soils and reliable rainfall, making it ideal for perennial crops. Kyenjojo District, strategically located along major trade routes, has become a hub for avocado expansion. Royal Plant Nurseries (RPN), established in 2009, has pioneered the propagation of Hass avocado seedlings, distributing 60,000–80,000 seedlings annually to outgrowers nationwide. Building on lessons from Wakiso, where farmers earn up to UGX 10 million per acre annually, RPN is scaling Hass avocado adoption in Kyenjojo to replicate similar economic success.

OPERATIONS AND FARMER SUPPORT

- **Seedling Distribution:** RPN supplies grafted Hass avocado seedlings, ensuring genetic purity and disease resistance.
- **Extension Services:** Farmers receive training on orchard establishment, pruning, pest management, and post harvest handling.
- **Community Partnerships:** RPN promotes intercropping with beans, enhancing soil fertility and food security.
- **Market Linkages:** Through partnerships with exporters and the Grain Council of Uganda, RPN connects farmers to regional and international buyers.



ECONOMIC VIABILITY

Evidence from Wakiso shows Hass avocado farming is highly profitable. In Kyenjojo, similar conditions suggest comparable returns:

- **Yield Potential:** Mature Hass avocado trees produce 200–300 fruits annually. With proper management, farmers can achieve 8–10 tons per hectare.
- **Income Estimates:** At export prices of UGX 1,500–2,000 per fruit, farmers can earn UGX 8–10 million per acre per year.
- **Cost Structure:** Initial investment in seedlings, land preparation, and inputs is offset by long term returns, as trees remain productive for decades.
- **Employment:** Orchard management creates jobs for youth and women, from planting to harvesting and packaging.



IMPACT ON LOCAL FARMERS

- **Increased Income:** Farmers in Kyenjojo report higher earnings compared to traditional crops like maize or beans.
- **Improved Livelihoods:** Avocado farming enhances food security and provides cash income for school fees, healthcare, and housing.
- **Community Empowerment:** Over 100,000 farmers nationwide benefit from RPN's seedlings, with Kyenjojo emerging as a key beneficiary.
- **Export Readiness:** Farmers are being trained to meet international standards, reducing rejection rates.



GOVERNMENT SUPPORT

The Ministry of Agriculture, Animal Industry and Fisheries (MAAIF) has rallied farmers to grow Hass avocado, recognizing its export potential. Programs like NAADS provide training, seedlings, and incentives.

The Parish Development Model (PDM) further supports small scale farmers by integrating them into commercial agriculture. RPN's work aligns closely with these initiatives, making it a vital private sector partner.

CHALLENGES

- **Quality Standards:**
Farmers must meet strict export requirements; poor post harvest handling leads to losses.
- **Market Access:**
Middlemen exploit farmers with low farm gate prices.
- **Climate Change:**
Unpredictable rainfall and pests threaten yields.
- **Infrastructure:**
Limited cold storage and transport facilities hinder export competitiveness.

OPPORTUNITIES

- **Global Demand:**
Rising demand for Hass avocado in Europe, Asia, and the Middle East.
- **Value Addition:**
Plans for an avocado oil and processing factory in Ngenzi, Kyenjojo District.
- **Research Collaboration:**
RPN works with NARO to develop climate resilient varieties.
- **PDM Integration:**
Hass avocado offers a pathway for parish households to join the money economy.



CONTRIBUTION TO PARISH DEVELOPMENT MODEL (PDM)

RPN's initiatives directly support PDM beneficiaries in Kyenjojo:

- **Seedlings & Training:**

Farmers receive planting materials and knowledge to establish orchards.

- **Local Wealth Creation:**

Avocado farming generates cash income, reducing poverty.

- **Market Linkages:**

Farmers are connected to exporters, ensuring fair prices.

- **Mindset Change:**

Sensitization campaigns encourage farmers to embrace Hass avocado as a commercial crop.

COMPARATIVE INSIGHTS: WAKISO VS. KYENJOJO

- **WAKISO:**

Proximity to Kampala and export hubs; demonstrated profitability.

- **KYENJOJO:**

Fertile soils, strong institutional support from RPN, and integration into PDM. Both regions show Hass avocado is economically viable, but Kyenjojo offers greater potential for scaling due to land availability and community mobilization.

CONCLUSION

Hass avocado production is economically viable for small scale farmers in Kyenjojo District, Rwenzori Region. With support from Royal Plant Nurseries, government programs, and the Parish Development Model, farmers can achieve significant incomes, improve livelihoods, and contribute to Uganda's export growth.

RPN's role

as a research enabled nursery and extension provider ensures sustainability and resilience, positioning Kyenjojo as a future hub for avocado production in Uganda.

RECOMMENDATIONS

1. **Scale Up Seedling Distribution:**

Expand RPN's reach to more parishes in Kyenjojo.

2. **Strengthen Market Infrastructure:**

Invest in cold storage, transport, and certification.

3. **Enhance Farmer Training:**

4. **Promote Value Addition:**

Support establishment of avocado oil and processing factories.

5. **Integrate with PDM:**

Ensure Hass avocado is prioritized in parish development plans.

COLOPHON

This case study was published in the context of the National Strategic Cluster –Tooro Sub Region, working closely with the Uganda Development Forum and its affiliate Tooro Development Forum partners. Rev. Atuhire Moses, National Strategic Cluster – Tooro Region, Chris Kaijuka, National Strategic Cluster– Tooro Region and Edward Katende, Uganda Development Forum.

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